



I DON'T REALLY THINK ABOUT MONEY; MY PARENTS HANDLE THAT. I PLAY CHESS BECAUSE I LOVE IT AND WANT TO ACHIEVE SOMETHING MEANINGFUL

India will definitely be one of the favourites, if not the favourite, in competitions like the Chess Olympiad.

What's your take on the upcoming World Championship match between Ding Liren and Gukesh?

As a chess player and fan, I hope we see some exciting games. I'd love for the match to go down to the wire, though I'm not sure if that will happen. Gukesh is the favourite because he's been playing at a very high level, while Ding hasn't been at his best. But this is the World Championship, and Ding has experience in high-pressure situations. It's going to be tough.

You've said you focus on your own goals rather than external expectations. What are your current goals?

Right now, I'm focused on increasing my rating. If I stay in the right mindset and continue playing good-quality chess, I believe I can break into the world's top five. That's my goal.

How has RB Ramesh influenced your growth, and how important are India's top trainers like Vishnu Prasanna, N. Srinath, and Abhijit Kunte?

Ramesh sir has played a massive role in my life. We've worked on everything — chess, mindset, life philosophies and even physical fitness. My father and Ramesh (sir) also handle off-the-board matters like dealing with the media and sponsors.

We're fortunate in India to have some of the best trainers, like Ramesh (sir), Srinath, and Vishnu sir. One key difference between Indian

Strong bond: R. Praggnanandhaa stands alongside his two pillars of strength: his mother, Nagalakshmi, and his sister, fellow Grandmaster R. Vaishali. FIDE/MICHAL WALUSZA

and foreign trainers is that Indian coaches form a personal bond with their players. They don't just focus on chess but also help with other aspects of life, which has made a big difference in my development.

Do you think India needs more Open tournaments to help young, underrated players gain experience and exposure?

Yes, Indian players are generally underrated, which is why we need more Open tournaments in the country.

These events give young players the chance to compete against top players and learn from them. While tournaments in Chennai and Delhi are good, we need more. Corporate involvement in chess is essential to support these events.